

The Container Size Cheat Sheet

Every number below is tied to a real root or growth mechanism, not a rounded-off average. The single most important column here is Variety — most container-size confusion online comes from advice that skips it entirely.

Crop	Variety	Min. Container	Min. Depth	Sunlight	Note
Tomato	Determinate (bush)	5–10 gal	12"	6–8 hrs	Root growth stops at fruit-set
Tomato	Indeterminate (vining)	15–20+ gal	18–24"	6–8 hrs	Roots keep expanding all season
Tomato	Cherry / dwarf	2–5 gal	8–12"	6–8 hrs	Root system matches small fruit size
Pepper	Bell	3–5 gal	10–12"	6+ hrs	Larger fruit load, larger root mass
Pepper	Hot (jalapeño, cayenne)	1–3 gal	8–10"	6+ hrs	Compact root system vs. bell types
Cucumber	Bush variety	5 gal	12"	6+ hrs	Self-limiting growth, no trellis
Cucumber	Vining variety	5–10 gal	12"+	6+ hrs	Needs trellis; roots active all season
Lettuce / Greens	Loose-leaf	6" deep, any width	6"	4–6 hrs	Spacing matters more than depth
Lettuce / Greens	Head (butterhead, romaine)	8" deep, 8" spacing	8"	4–6 hrs	Needs more per-plant space
Herbs	Rosemary, thyme, sage, oregano	1–2 gal	8"	6+ hrs	Needs fast drainage, not more room
Herbs	Basil, parsley, cilantro	1–2 gal	8"	4–6 hrs	Needs consistent moisture
Herbs	Mint (any variety)	1–2 gal, isolated	8"	4–6 hrs	Always give it its own container

Why variety changes the number

Root systems don't scale with the plant's overall size — they scale with how long the plant keeps growing. Determinate and bush-type plants stop expanding their roots once they set fruit, which is why a smaller container genuinely is correct for them, not a compromise. Indeterminate and vining types never get that signal, so their roots keep pace with the plant until frost. Sizing every plant in a "crop family" the same way is the single most common cause of a container that looked fine in June and was root-bound by August.

Your container garden — fill this in

Container	Crop + Variety	Size	Sunlight Spot	Planted
